

The KDP Rejection Decoder

What the rejection actually means, written from twenty-one attempts rather than from a manual.

Read this with your last rejection email open beside you. It is built to be used against a real rejection, not in the abstract.

Before anything else, the single most useful fact about your situation:

The print requirements are published. The rejection just does not tell you which one you missed. The information is public and the diagnosis is private — and that gap, not your writing, is what stops most people.

Once you see it that way it stops being a locked door and becomes what it actually is: a checklist you were being asked to run blindfolded. This guide takes the blindfold off.

How to work

Check in the order below. Trim size comes first for a reason — if the page size is wrong, every margin measurement is being taken against the wrong page, and you will spend a day "fixing" things that were never broken.

Change one thing at a time and write down what you changed. The reason attempt twelve feels hopeless is almost always that by then you have altered six settings at once and cannot tell which one helped.

Where a specific number matters, get it from Amazon's own current specification.

Thresholds change, and a number copied into a guide goes stale quietly. This document tells you what is being measured; their spec tells you what it has to measure.

The five that catch almost everyone

1. Trim size

Your PDF page has to be the exact physical size of the book format you selected. Not close — exact.

Most common cause: the manuscript was set up in one size, the book format was changed later, and the page setup was never revisited.

CHECK: open the PDF's document properties and read the page size. Compare it, digit for digit, against the trim size on your title's setup.

2. Margins and the gutter

Text must sit inside the printable area, and the inside margin — the gutter — has to be wider than the outside one, because part of it disappears into the spine.

The part that surprises people: the required gutter grows with page count. A longer book needs more of it, so a file that was fine at one length can fail at another with nothing about the settings having changed.

CHECK: look at the innermost text on a left-hand and a right-hand page. If anything sits close to the spine edge, that is your candidate.

3. Fonts that are not embedded

This is the cruel one, because your file looks perfect on your own screen. It looks perfect because the font is installed on your computer. The printer does not have your computer.

If the font is not embedded inside the PDF itself, it does not exist as far as the print process is concerned. This catches almost everybody who exports from a word processor with default settings.

CHECK: PDF document properties has a Fonts tab. Every font listed should say it is embedded, or embedded as a subset. Anything that does not is the problem.

4. Bleed

If an image runs all the way to the edge of the page, it has to extend slightly past the edge, because the paper is trimmed after printing and no trim lands perfectly.

Without bleed you get a thin white sliver where you wanted a full-page image — or a rejection before you ever see it. Note this only applies to elements meant to touch the edge; a book with no full-bleed images does not need to worry about it.

CHECK: does anything in your interior run to the paper edge? If yes, it needs bleed and the page has to be built for it from the start.

5. Image resolution

Screens are forgiving and print is not. An image that looks sharp in your document can be nowhere near enough detail once it is ink on paper.

Most common cause: an image saved from a website. Web images are sized for screens, and screens need a fraction of the detail print does.

CHECK: find the original of every image and look at its pixel dimensions against the size it prints at. If you had to enlarge it to fit, it is suspect.

Reading the rejection itself

Rejection wording is general by design, so treat it as a category rather than an instruction. In practice:

Anything mentioning **size, dimensions or the page** sends you to items 1 and 2. Anything mentioning **fonts or text** sends you to item 3. Anything mentioning **images, quality, bleed or the cover** sends you to items 4 and 5. Anything you cannot place at all — run the list in order anyway. It is five checks and it is faster than another blind resubmission.

The order that saves you months

1. Fix trim size. Confirm it in the PDF's own properties, not in the program you exported from.
2. Re-check margins *after* the trim size is right, because they were being measured against the wrong page.
3. Confirm every font embeds.
4. Handle bleed only if something actually touches the edge.

5. Replace low-resolution images with originals.
6. Re-export and check the exported file — not the source document. The export is what gets judged.

What I will not tell you

I am not going to promise you an approval. Nobody outside Amazon can, and anybody who does is telling you something they cannot know.

Here is the honest version, and it is the version that is actually useful:

Checking your PDF against KDP's published formatting requirements before you upload is what turns a blind resubmission into an informed one. Amazon still runs their own review and makes their own decision. You are simply no longer guessing at what they are looking at.

That is the whole difference, and it was the whole problem. It was never the writing.

If you would rather have it checked than check it by hand

Everything above you can do yourself, and plenty of people do. I built **Manu2Print** for the moment when you would rather not: upload the PDF and you get back a full compliance report, an annotated copy with every issue flagged by page, plain -English fix instructions, and one free recheck. No subscription, and credits never expire.

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